

Redefining Foundational Education in Uttar Pradesh

For a long time, discussions on basic education in Uttar Pradesh have focused on issues such as school infrastructure, teacher availability, and enrolment rates. However, in recent years, the scope of educational reform has expanded far beyond school buildings and access. Under the leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the focus has shifted to what children are learning and how they are learning. As a result, the state's education reform agenda now extends beyond infrastructure to encompass learning outcomes, reading culture, early childhood education, teacher capacity building, scientific temper, and nutrition. Through the initiatives launched for the academic session 2026-27, the government has signalled its intent to develop Uttar Pradesh's education system into a national model, where a child's learning journey begins at the Anganwadi level and progresses towards innovation-driven and technology-enabled education.

Recognising the growing screen time among children in the digital age and the declining habit of reading, the Yogi Adityanath Government has launched a comprehensive campaign to strengthen reading culture in schools. The government believes that the habit of reading is not merely a means to secure better examination results; it also forms the foundation of language proficiency, logical thinking, communication skills, and creative expression. With this objective, activities such as regular reading hours, newspaper reading, news presentation during morning assemblies, and book discussions are being institutionalised in parishadiya vidyalaya and secondary schools. The 'DEAR' (Drop Everything and Read) campaign is also being implemented effectively, under which students, teachers, and headmasters devote a designated period to reading books of their choice. The government has introduced initiatives such as the 'Super-20' Reading Challenge at the primary level and the 'Super-30' Reading Challenge at the upper primary level. Students who read the highest number of books will be recognised, and a provision has also been made to declare a 'Champion Reader of the Year' at the school level. At the same time, children are being encouraged to go beyond reading by participating in book reviews, writing competitions, and a range of creative activities, fostering a richer and more engaging learning experience.

Balvatika lays the foundation

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 recognises Early Childhood Care and Education as the most crucial stage in a child's learning journey. In line with this vision, the Yogi Adityanath Government has, for the first time, taken large-scale steps towards systematically strengthening pre-primary education across the state. The distribution of activity-based learning materials has commenced in co-located Anganwadi Centres and Balvatikas for children in the 3–6 years age group. Educational resources such as Chahak-1, 2, 3, Kadam, Kalankur, Big Books, Holistic Report Cards, and Balvatika Booklets have been developed to enrich children's early learning experiences. Education experts believe that this is the age when language skills, cognitive abilities, social behaviour, and curiosity develop most rapidly. In such a scenario, play-based and activity-oriented learning methods naturally encourage children to engage with the learning process. To monitor the distribution of these materials, the government has also developed a 'Kitab Vitaran App' (Book Distribution App). This ensures that educational resources reach children in real time while maintaining transparency throughout the distribution process.

